

Bright Register

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FRONT PAGE

Used Car Of The Day: 2012 BMW X5 35d

Tim Healey · The Truth About Cars

An oil-burning Bimmer? Why not? Today we give you a 2012 BMW X5 35d as our Used Car of the Day.

This one is pretty loaded with convenience features such as heated seats, heated steering wheel, the Sport package, a panoramic sunroof, navigation, and more. It's set up for towing.

The seller says that maintenance has been kept up to date, and there are two sets of wheels/tires on offer as part of the deal.

The mileage is 149,000.

You can see more by [clicking here](#) . The asking price is \$11,900 and this one is for sale in Bend, Oregon.

[Images: Seller]

Become a TTAC insider. Get the latest news, features, TTAC takes, and everything else that gets to the truth about cars first by [subscribing to our newsletter](#) .

FEATURES

Emil Nygård: 500px Photographer Spotlight

500px Blog · 500px ISO

There is an undeniable magnetism in Emil Nygård's work. Recently named 500px Popular Photographer of the Year 2025, Emil Nygård has captured the attention of the PULSEpx community with his intimate wildlife portraits. Whether trekking through the humid depths of a rainforest or scaling a jagged ridge, he manages to return with portraits that feel less like wildlife documentation and more like an intimate conversation. Recently named the 500px Popular Photographer of the Year 2025 by the PULSEpx community, Emil sits down with us to discuss the patience, the philosophy, and the singular moment that defined his year.

In this interview, Emil Nygård shares how curiosity, patience, and respect for wildlife shape the way he approaches photography.

The Wildlife Photography Journey of Emil Nygård

To start at the very beginning, what was the initial spark that led you to pick up a camera and dedicate your life to exploring the natural world?

I wouldn't say I set out to dedicate my life to photography. I'm still very much a happy amateur with a regular job and a deep curiosity about the world, but I've always been fascinated by animals. As a child, I could spend hours watching documentaries on Animal Planet, listening to David Attenborough narrate stories from places that felt almost mythical. Africa, in particular, stayed with me. Long before photography entered the picture, I dreamed of experiencing those landscapes and wildlife encounters for myself.

In August 2024, I went on my first dedicated safari in Tanzania. Before the trip, I made a conscious decision to buy my first serious camera, a Canon EOS R8. I wanted to do the experience justice. I didn't expect it to change anything profoundly, but somewhere between the dust, the silence, and the wildlife moving freely across the savannah, something shifted. I was completely hooked.

When I returned home to Norway, I invested further, upgrading to a Canon EOS R3 and a Canon RF 100–500mm lens, not because I suddenly saw myself as a professional, but because I wanted to keep improving. I still do. Each journey is an opportunity to observe more carefully and hopefully become just a little better than I was before.

I feel incredibly fortunate to have the opportunity to travel. That's not something I take for granted. A big part of why I share my images and write about my journeys is that I know not everyone has the same chance to stand in those places. If someone can feel like they are part of the experience through my work, even briefly, then it feels meaningful beyond myself.

Africa strengthened a dream that had been there for years. Photography simply became the way I chose to live it.

Your portfolio has a distinct sense of atmosphere that feels cinematic. How much of your style is a result of your technical environment versus your own internal creative intuition?

I didn't consciously set out to create something cinematic, but I take that as a huge compliment. The environment definitely plays a role. When you're standing in golden African light or surrounded by deep jungle shadows, there's already a natural drama in the scene. Good equipment helps me capture the detail and depth I see in front of me, but I don't believe gear alone creates atmosphere.

A big part of it is how the moment feels. When I edit my images, I lean into that feeling. I'll often adjust tones, contrast, and light to enhance the mood I experienced when I was there. I'm not trying to change reality; I'm trying to translate it. I want the viewer to sense what it felt like to stand in that exact place.

What people describe as "cinematic" may simply be my attempt to slow the image down, to create tension in a gaze, to let shadows breathe, and to give the subject space within the frame. I'm still learning and experimenting. My style isn't something I engineered; it's something that's gradually forming as I continue to explore both the world and my own way of seeing it.

When we look at your winning photograph of the lizard, the detail is staggering, but it is the personality in the eye that truly captivates. Can you walk us through the day you captured this shot and what was going through your mind in that specific moment?

The photograph was taken in Sinharaja Forest Reserve in Sri Lanka during sunrise. It had already been an eventful morning, to put it mildly, but by the time I stepped into the rainforest, everything felt still again. The forest was dense, humid, and alive with sound. Soft morning light filtered through the canopy, creating pockets of shadow and glow. When I first spotted the lizard clinging to a tree trunk, I was immediately drawn to its eye. There was something alert, almost curious, in its expression.

I didn't wait for hours, but it wasn't easy either. I had a specific vision for the background, a smooth, natural blur that would isolate the subject and create depth. As I carefully repositioned myself, the lizard kept moving around the trunk, almost as if we were circling each other. It became a quiet negotiation. I stayed calm and patient, conscious that I was a guest in its world.

For about thirty minutes, I adjusted my position inch by inch, trying not to disturb the moment.

Then it happened: the lizard paused, the background aligned, the light softened, and I took a short burst of frames.

When I looked down at the back of my camera, I remember thinking, "Yes, this is the one." Outwardly, I try to remain

Resolving Incidents With The Remote Incident Console

Alistair Forrester Burrowes · Zendesk Engineering

Supporting developers to debug and resolve issues with datastores in the Self-Service ecosystem.

Welcome to the third blog post of our Self-Service Datastore series, where we share our journey towards creating a more efficient and reliable way to manage datastores at Zendesk.

Previous blog posts:

Unlocking Efficiency: A New Era for Datastore Provisioning

Simplifying Datastore Provisioning with Kubernetes Operators

We need reliable, fast, and compliant self-serve methods to provision datastores. Furthermore, we need to ways to access those datastores from applications; otherwise, they won't serve much purpose. The full story of how we provision credentials for Self-Service Datastores and access them from applications is for another day. Today, I want to talk about another key scenario where we need to facilitate access.

Our application

Before we get into the scenario, let's take a look at our application. This is the service.yaml which lives in our application repository and is the entrypoint into the Self-Service ecosystem.

```
version: "1.0" name: "wishmaker" description: "A service for managing wish requests." product: "wishmania" team: "wishers"
```

```
infrastructure: aurora:
```

- name: "wish-inventory"

```
attributes: instanceType: "db.t4g.medium" redis:
```

- name: "wish-cache"

```
attributes: nodeType: "cache.r7g.large" clusterModeEnabled: true purpose: cache
```

In short, our application is wishmaker and we have a Self-Service Aurora MySQL wish-inventory and Self-Service Redis wish-cache. Given this setup, what is the scenario? ☹

🔊 🔊 PROD IS DOWN 🔊 🔊

Everyone panic!!!!

That might be triggering ☹ ... but we all know that sometimes things go wrong and our applications break. Excluding all the communication and collaboration required for the incident, we will need engineers to:

Assess what has gone wrong.

Perform mitigations or fixes.

We often need engineers to assess what is happening and perform fixes in the database directly. How can we support engineers to directly access the database in the Self-Service ecosystem?

Remote Incident Console (RIC)

We need some way for developers to easily get a console that has access to their Self-Service Datastores. This needs to be quick and easy and for that we developed the Remote Incident Console (RIC). How does it work?

```
$ ric -partition pod73 -service wishmaker -incident inc-2025-02-18-a
```

Woah! Slow down!

Ok what does this command do? It says:

ric - I want a RIC console.

-partition pod73 - We need to connect to the application running on the pod73 Zendesk Partition (a regional slice of all of Zendesk, with an underlying Kubernetes cluster).

-service wishmaker - The application (and more importantly, the owner of the datastores I need to access) is wishmaker

-incident inc-2025-02-18-a - This investigation is related to the inc-2025-02-18-a incident. The incident id is used for a variety of purposes.

What do you get?

This creates a Kubernetes pod in the application namespace (wishmaker in this case) and automatically runs `kubectl exec -it /bin/bash` to give the user a console.

```
❏ Requesting new OKTA token ❏ Initiating RIC RIC Session requested with the following details Team: wishers Partition: pod73 Environment: production User: alistair.burrowes Service: wishmaker Incident ID: inc-2025-02-18-a
```

```
❏ Session creating ... (10s) ❏ Taking you to your Session ❏ Your RIC Session will be valid until [ 2025-02-19 03:10:20 +1100 ]
```

```
ric-console@wishmaker-ricpod-tccx4:/app$
```

RIC console

Now that we are in and have a console, we want to connect to our Self-Service Aurora MySQL database known as wish-inventory. How do we do that?

Well we can use our handy aurora command, e. g.:

```
ric-console@wishmaker-ricpod-tccx4:/app$ aurora wish-inventory
```

Volkswagen Might Be Making Arms For Israel

Matt Posky · *The Truth About Cars*

Volkswagen is reportedly in the midst of discussions with an Israeli defense company, named Rafael Advanced Defense Systems, about converting its Osnabrück plant to produce weapons. The facility was reportedly in danger of being shuttered indefinitely, with the deal being framed as a way to retain over 2,000 local jobs.

Volkswagen Group apparently has ethical concerns regarding the production of offensive weapons, so the talks are reportedly focused on the prospect of the facility manufacturing components for Israel's "Iron Dome" missile defense network.

According to the Financial Times, VW had previously been in talks with German arms and armored vehicle manufacturer Rheinmetall. The Osnabrück facility is presently responsible for building the Volkswagen T-Roc Cabriolet (pictured), which is slated to end production by the middle of 2027. But that deal is rumored to have stagnated, despite the duo having worked together in the past on military trucks.

Details about the prospective arrangement with Rafael Advanced Defense Systems are limited. Volkswagen has clearly been trying to decide what it should do with its Osnabrück plant and just about everything seems to be on the table. Volkswagen has suggested leasing the plant to other companies, using it to build low-volume specialty vehicles from one of its subbrands, or simply selling it off to another business.

It sounds as though the deal would be a collaborative project where VW manufactured components on behalf of the Israeli weapons firm. But the company has been unwilling to confirm anything with the press and has been very careful to avoid language that would make it sound like it's producing weapons.

"The production of weapons by Volkswagen AG remains ruled out," a spokesperson recently told Euronews Business, adding that it did not want to "engage in speculation regarding further plans for the Osnabrück site."

While it confirmed that it was "in dialogue with various market players," it stated that nothing concrete had been decided. Still, there are numerous outlets suggesting insiders are confirming the deal as more-or-less completed.

Considering that automakers are looking at declining volumes and mounting global conflict, military contracts may become highly sought after. People may not be able to afford to buy modern automobiles at the rates they used to. But governments may still be willing to leverage tax dollars to pay for weapons systems as war continues to spread.

Most of the world's largest automakers have spent at least some of their time moonlighting as weapons manufacturers. A few have even kept one foot in the door in the hopes

of garnering lucrative government contracts. For example, General Motors has a division wholly devoted to military applications called GM defense.

But it's more common to see brands pivoting manufacturing efforts as needed. Volkswagen originated as a union-backed initiative to create affordable, reliable cars at the behest of the German government in 1937. But it only took a couple of years before World War II broke out in earnest and its facilities were repurposed to produce military vehicles.

The company continued building military vehicles after the war, primarily for the British and American armies, and would sporadically manufacture units for the German army during the Cold War. But it really hasn't done much since then.

Considering that Germany has been strengthening its relationship with Israel in recent years, the deal with VW seems plausible. Germany even expanded its deal for the Israeli-made Arrow-3 hypersonic missile defense to the tune of \$6.5 billion last December. The European nation has also been buying Israeli-designed trophy systems to be adapted for military vehicles and there's even been talk of establishing an "Iron Dome" over German airspace.

That alone might be sufficient to solidify plans for Volkswagen's Osnabrück factory. But the unionized labor force would still need to sign onto the plan. While government support of Israel remains quite strong, civilian support has been on the decline. A poll referenced by the Jerusalem Post in 2025 even suggested that a majority of Germans (62 percent) strongly opposed Israeli military actions — potentially confronting VW's Osnabrück employees with a difficult decision.

Volkswagen isn't doing well right now and already has a deal with the relevant labor union to eliminate roughly 40,000 jobs over the next several years. Those people will eventually need jobs.

Meanwhile, European automakers have shown a general willingness to spend more of their R&D budget on military programs — presumably in anticipation that they'll be able to profit during wartime while economic conditions make it more difficult to sell automobiles.

Renault is preparing to manufacture long-range drones. While these were originally framed these as "defensive drones" to be used for surveillance, they can and will be adapted to carry munitions should the military wish to use them in attacking targets. Stellantis likewise looked to be considering manufacturing weapons, especially in Italy, as a way to cope with declining vehicle sales. However, corporate leadership has since expressed that it doesn't see its future overlapping with the defense industry.

That said, Stellantis still provides vehicles for law enforcement and government agencies, some of which featured armor and turrets used for mounting weapons. The latter units come by way of corporate partnerships with busi-

The Power of Assumption

ysamuels · LessWrong

(First real Lesswrong post! Wow. This is a post on an idea I thought might be interesting to some people here, and I'd love to hear thoughts on it.)

Assumption can be used as a communicative tool.

As a kid I would occasionally, before falling asleep, lie in bed and imagine that I had a very good friend to talk to, or who could cheer me on. Sometimes these were characters from my favorite books, but apparently at some point it occurred to me that presumably someone, somewhere, could be supposed to have anticipated someone else in the world feeling that way at some point, and might actually have wanted to send that someone a message of comfort, love, or support. At this point, all I had to do was imagine roughly what they might say, consider it to be said, and the message would have been received. To put it differently, I was aware that many, probably most, of the people in the world, knowing that I felt lonely, might have wanted to send me their blessings or support, and that presumably, at least one person who felt that way, over all space and time, probably realized that he could send me that message, provided I was smart enough to realize he might try to.

So I could “communicate” with people, when the purpose was therapeutic in that way - I couldn't actually receive ideas I couldn't have thought of myself (by definition), but when it was the communication itself and not the words that mattered, I could receive the messages left for me by people who had found this mental space that was created by the assumption that others would . If I wanted to give as well as receive, I could “leave” messages too, for any future or past thinker, lonely or otherwise, to assume exist. Despite the obvious drawback of not being able to receive any idea you couldn't have thought of yourself, this communication does allow you to completely bypass constraints of language, time and space.

Assumption is famously used in problems where the goal is to meet with someone over varying areas when you have no (other) mode of communication. I personally had idly wondered for some years what the best way to meet with someone spoken to by assumption would be (assuming they had also considered the possibility of meeting). I remained stuck for quite some time wondering whether it was the Eiffel Tower or the Empire State Building that would be the best place to go at midnight, January first, with a big sign reading “You know why you're here. Talk to me”, before realizing that the appropriate place on the internet was probably a much more logical rendezvous (thought that is not the main motive for me in writing here - I've wanted to contribute to LessWrong for some time now).

Just as another point of thought, communication through assumption could in theory be used to create intellectual taboos or norms among intelligent people, for example an accepted and implicit censoring of certain ideas or beliefs

that could be realized by anyone smart enough to arrive at them as being unsuitable for spreading (I really hope this isn't one of those).

So:

1. Do you know anyone who has beaten me to writing about this? Please direct me to the source if so. (I hope not, but I do hope it has been thought about before, otherwise I've been played for quite a fool).
2. Do you think this idea is worth anything? Other than game theory , in what other fields or ways could it be used?
3. Have I ever spoken to you telepathically before? If so, please write. That could be a very interesting conversation.

Less is More: Improving job execution by ditching the job executor

Tim Cuthbertson · Zendesk Engineering

A brutally simple and effective implementation for long-running account move jobs at Zendesk.

This article outlines some architectural changes we've been able to make to radically simplify the execution model of long-running jobs.

By leveraging client behaviour, the resulting system improves overall functionality while removing the many complexities of distributed job execution.

Dall-e impression of a server who's ready to move some data!

Background: Account moves at Zendesk

Behind the scenes at Zendesk, the data for a given customer account lives in one of our regions across the globe. We don't want an account to be forever in the original datacenter it was created, so we have robust account move tooling which allows us to move an account to a new region with near-zero downtime.

This tooling is a valuable capability which helps our customers as well as ourselves. It was first built to scale out of our single Rackspace deployment into multiple datacenters, and was crucial again many years later to migrate out of those datacenters into AWS. It's still in routine use for balancing capacity and other metrics across our various datacenters. And more recently, this tooling has been instrumental in migrating the services from acquired companies into our shared infrastructure.

The account move tooling involves a central orchestrator plus a number of data movers. The orchestrator manages the overall account move lifecycle, coordinating the various systems as the move progresses. The job of actually moving bytes around is typically done by data movers — there's one for each of our supported datastores.

Welcome aboard! Please place your belongings within the Zendesk infrastructure

So when we acquire a company which uses a datastore we don't have a mover for, we have a challenge.

The first and easiest solution is “can we stop doing that?”. If there's a supported datastore which would also work well, we'll migrate to that.

If that's not an option and the data needs to be moved, then that typically calls for a new data mover. This is a lot of work so we undertake it reluctantly, but having data indefinitely stuck outside the core Zendesk infrastructure makes things complex, and locks the acquired product out of many organisational benefits.

So when it comes to integrating acquisitions into our shared infrastructure, the complexity of building a data mover has a big impact.

Data movers are job execution servers

The details of how data gets moved are important and interesting, but today we're focusing on job management, because data movers implement jobs. What makes something a job? At its core, I think of a job as something which is:

Long running (if it were short it could just be a request), and

Monitored for completion (if you're not waiting for its completion, you could just fire off an event or notification and walk away)

In addition to these typical properties, our data mover jobs are usually continuous. They replicate data from a source system into a destination system, keeping up with new changes as they arrive. So we keep them running until the overall account move is complete.

Typical job system API

If we have jobs, we'll probably need a system for running jobs. For these jobs our orchestrator is the client which asks for jobs to run, and each data mover is the server which implements those jobs.

Most systems for long-running jobs (including our initial implementation) have an API that looks a bit like this:

StopJob(jobId)

Example sequence for this job API

The API is simple, but it must support a number of requirements to be a suitable executor for data movement jobs.

No job left behind! If a client creates a job, the server must not forget about it after a crash or restart.

Fault tolerance

Jobs can run for a long time, and Kubernetes containers don't last forever. If a container crashes or is replaced, the job needs to keep making progress by having another container take over.

Interruptions should not cause the job to start over, a job should pick up from (close to) where it left off.

We don't want two instances to execute the same job at the same time.

Dangling jobs

If the client forgets about a job for whatever reason, we don't want to be executing that job forever as it's wasteful and may even cause issues if the client doesn't expect that work to be happening. We want to detect dangling jobs and stop them.

Destinations in Focus: Cities Through a Cinematic Lens

500px Blog · 500px ISO

Introducing Destinations in Focus

An exclusive collaboration between 500px and Trip.com

We're inviting photographers to capture three iconic cities from a fresh, cinematic perspective. This isn't about postcard photography. It's about atmosphere, motion, scale, and storytelling that elevate landmark photography beyond the obvious.

Submissions are open from March 3, 2026 and close on April 16, 2026.

About Trip.com

Trip.com is a leading global travel agency, helping millions of travellers discover destinations, book experiences, and explore the world with confidence. Through its platform, Trip.com showcases cities, attractions, and cultural highlights to a worldwide audience. This collaboration offers photographers the opportunity to have their work featured editorially on a global travel platform, placing strong city imagery directly in front of international travellers.

If you have a compelling travel archive or access to one of these cities, this is your opportunity to turn landmark photography into meaningful editorial exposure.

Prize & Licensing Details

This Quest series rewards both standout individual images and consistent quality across submissions.

Between 20 and 50 photos will be selected to be featured editorially on Trip.com.

Each selected photo will earn its photographer an editorial licensing fee per image .

Multiple photographers may be selected. Individual photographers may also have multiple photos chosen.

For each Quest Trip.com and 500px Editors will select one Grand Prize Winner.

The winner will be chosen based on:

Overall quality

Cinematic perspective

Professional execution

The number of their photos selected to be featured

The Grand Prize will range between \$20 and \$50 USD, with the final amount determined by the total number of that photographer's selected images featured on Trip.com.

What We're Looking For

Atmospheric & New Perspectives: Avoid cliché "postcard" shots. Use creative angles like drone photography, low-angle perspectives, or foreground occlusion (e.g., shooting through foliage). Capture the scale of the city with panoramas, time lapses, or car light trails.

Immersive Storytelling: Create a "first-person POV" feel. Show us what it's like to walk through a park or visit a market stall. Capture a sense of motion from the blur of a passing bus or the flow of people in a busy plaza.

Local Culture: Focus on authentic moments like people chatting at outdoor cafes (side or back shots are best for licensing) or street performers in action.

Weather & Time: Use the environment to your advantage. Whether it's a golden sun flare over a park or a night scene illuminated by city lights, capture the character of Madrid at its most cinematic.

We're launching the first chapter of Destinations in Focus with three iconic cities; Madrid, Amsterdam, and Edinburgh with more destinations to be announced soon.

Destinations in Focus: Madrid

Madrid is a city of movement and warmth, from late-night streets glowing under golden light to bustling markets layered with texture and life. The visual language here is dynamic. Think scale, motion, and energy that feels lived-in rather than staged.

We're looking for images that capture the vibrancy of the city through immersive angles and thoughtful composition.

Featured locations include:

Mercado de San Miguel

Parque de Atracciones de Madrid

Whether it's a golden sun flare over a park or a night scene illuminated by city lights, capture the character of Madrid at its most cinematic.

500px Blog

Casa de Campo

Consider using long exposures to capture motion, golden-hour light to add atmosphere, or layered compositions that place the viewer directly inside the scene.

Get inspired

Submit your photos

2026 Aston Martin DBX S Review – Variation On A Theme

Bradley Iger · *The Truth About Cars*

Introduced back in 2020, the DBX became the best-selling model in Aston Martin's lineup shortly thereafter, proving once again that while sports coupes might be nice to look at and fun to drive on a good road, it's the SUVs that ensure an automaker's checks clear.

As such, the folks in Gaydon have given the high-riding five-seater a steady feed of updates in the time since, first with the huge performance improvements that came with the debut of the DBX707 in 2022, and then with the chassis tuning tweaks and tech glow-up that arrived for 2025.

Keen to strike while the iron is hot, the 2026 DBX S now serves as the flagship version of Aston Martin's super-sport-utility vehicle. First applied to the 2004 Vanquish, the S badge denotes an Aston Martin model that's been further honed in the name of performance, and in this case, that enhanced capability is achieved through a host of strategic tweaks rather than a comprehensive overhaul. And while that might sound a bit underwhelming at first blush, Aston Martin finds itself in the serendipitous position of not having to apologize for the complexity, bloat, and compromises to refinement that have infiltrated the super-SUV segment over the past few years.

It might be tempting to assume that this is Aston's answer to the Lamborghini Urus Performante, especially when you consider the racy weight-saving options like a carbon fiber roof (which replaces the panoramic glass roof that's standard for the DBX707), 23-inch magnesium wheels, and a lightweight polycarbonate grille, all of which contribute to a total weight savings of roughly 103 pounds over the DBX707.

The Mercedes-AMG-sourced 4.0-liter twin-turbocharged V8 also now produces 717 horsepower thanks to turbo tech borrowed from the Valhalla hypercar, while peak torque remains unchanged at 664 lb-ft. In the age of hybridization and performance EVs, those power numbers aren't as jaw-dropping as might have been just a few years ago, but it's worth pointing out that the 4,850-pound DBX S is nearly 700 pounds lighter than the Lamborghini Urus SE (not to mention the similarly-hefty G99 BMW M5 Touring) due in large part to the DBX S's lack of electric assistance.

Further aiding the DBX S's sense of urgency is revamped programming for nine-speed wet-clutch automatic transmission that's designed to make better use of the V8's top-end power while also delivering more aggressive shifts in Sport and Sport+ drive modes. The S also scores a steering ratio that's 4 percent quicker than the DBX707's, but that's pretty much it on the chassis front, as Aston Martin's engineers chose to leave last year's revised calibrations for the air springs and electronic dampers alone. Although that does allow for some squat and dive when you're really hustling out in the canyons, it wisely avoids the pervasive harshness of a track-honed suspension everywhere else. I'd

consider it to be a worthy trade-off in a five-seater SUV, even if it has an S badge on the fender.

A press of the ignition button push brings the V8 to life with an authoritative growl thanks to a new exhaust system that's tuned to be more emotive than the DBX707's. The reworked setup features vertically stacked tips at the rear, one of the few ways the DBX S can be visually differentiated from a DBX707 at a glance. A dedicated exhaust volume button on the center console allows you to toggle between subtly menacing and outright burly on the fly, but the cabin's excellent road noise isolation never allows the V8's soundtrack to become overbearing when the windows are up.

Speaking of which, the cabin is another aspect of the DBX S's design where Aston Martin's reluctance to embrace the latest automotive trends has worked out in its favor. As part of the 2025 refresh, the automaker finally ditched its woefully dated Mercedes infotainment tech in favor of a system designed completely in-house. Not only is the 10.25-inch touchscreen sharp and quick to respond to inputs, it also supports Apple CarPlay Ultra, which allows for more control over the vehicle's various features and ushers in additional personalization options for both the infotainment display and the 12.3-inch digital gauge cluster. Aston Martin also admirably resisted the urge to move all of the audio and HVAC controls to the touchscreen, instead opting for a handsome layout of buttons for often-used features like the auto stop/start system and damper stiffness, while the knurled metal dials used for functions like temperature and fan speed feel substantial and high-quality.

Despite its performance focus, around town the DBX S feels just as accommodating as the DBX707, if not more so. While the optional 23-inch magnesium wheels outfitted here command an eye-watering \$21,600 premium over the standard rollers, they reduce rotating unsprung mass by a 42 pounds, a substantial improvement that benefits acceleration and braking as well as handling and ride comfort. Left in its default GT drive mode, the DBX S glides over freeway expansion joints and pockmarked pavement with zero drama. Paired with sport seats that strike a great balance between comfort and support (but conspicuously lacked ventilation, a feature that should be obligatory in an SUV of this caliber), the DBX S delivers the kind of everyday civility that you'd expect from an ultra-luxury sport utility vehicle.

A trek out to some technical canyon roads reveals the other side of the DBX S's personality. Twisting the dial that surrounds the ignition button allows you to quickly switch between drive modes (GT, Sport, Sport+, Individual, and Terrain), with Sport+ delivering admirably flat cornering thanks to the 48-volt "eARC" system, the DBX S's active anti-roll control system. Combined with the quicker steering and lightweight wheels, the S feels noticeably more eager to turn in and change direction. But Aston Martin also wants the suspension in its road cars to "breathe," as they put it, so the impressive stopping power delivered by the massive carbon ceramic brakes is accompanied by a notable amount of dive when you're caning it.

Heartbeats

Luke Stephenson · Zendesk Engineering

Heartbeats: How Synthetic Traffic Keeps Us Running

Let me take you on a journey of how we came to use heartbeats in our application design. It's a happy story of love and no broken hearts along the way.

What are heartbeats?

What my teams have called heartbeats are a form of synthetic traffic generated by the application itself. The deployed application periodically generates heartbeats at a defined schedule.

Heartbeats provide guaranteed regular traffic. In the cases I've used them, they have been low volume. In contrast to application traffic, which could vary massively from zero to huge throughput depending on the cluster.

Sounds simple, why do I need heartbeats?

Thanks for asking. Let's go over some of the use cases that led to us introducing heartbeats.

Use case 1 — Escape

Escape is the name of the service we deploy at Zendesk to support transactional publishing to Kafka along with a write to MySQL. If an application team wants to update a database record AND publish to Kafka as a transaction, Escape is the way to do it. The application team also writes to an additional table the details of the message(s) that need to be published to Kafka, and Escape does the rest. This unburdens developers from having to solve the complex problem of guaranteeing transactional consistency across 2 data stores.

My team is responsible for deploying and managing Escape. As part of that, we want to alert on things like:

High latency between the data being inserted and published to Kafka

The pipeline halting / messages not flowing through the pipeline

Monitoring for the pipeline halting is an interesting case. The application itself can't be responsible for emitting a metric / triggering an alert that there is a problem with the pipeline being down. The root cause might be that the application is not even running!

Given the application can only emit that it is alive, we can alert when those metrics stop being emitted.

We use datadog for monitoring, and can use a query like the following to trigger an alert:

```
sum(last_5m):sum:escape.success{} by {cluster}.as_count() < 1.0
```

This query will alert if over the last 5 minutes there have been no events handled by Escape successfully. Note that the `by {cluster}` means that if any database cluster is not seeing events handled, the alert will tell us which cluster is experiencing issues.

So far, so good. What is the limitation of this approach? What if the customers on that cluster aren't performing any updates? What if it is a staging database cluster that doesn't have updates over the weekend when the devs are off skiing and surfing? That would trigger false alarms when everything is healthy.

To work around this, we generate heartbeats. For each cluster we are processing, we periodically insert a request to publish to Kafka. We send the messages to a heartbeats Kafka topic which nothing consumes, but doing so gives us full end to end confidence in the pipeline. Now we have solved our false alarms.

Not only have we solved our initial monitoring concern, we have also built an always-on smoke test for our functionality. If we deploy a version of our code that breaks the flow of data, we will receive an alert for it pretty quickly.

One limitation of this approach is that if there is an issue with the ingestion of metrics by datadog, then an alert will trigger even though everything is healthy. Contrast this with a latency monitor, if metrics aren't being ingested or there is a backlog of metrics to process, the latency monitor will not fire.

Also note that for a completely new database cluster, the monitor will not fire until there has been at least one successful metric emitted (the grouping by cluster needs to first be aware of all of the clusters). In practice we haven't found this to be an issue.

Use case 2 — Account Moves

Behind the scenes at Zendesk, the data for a given customer account lives in one of our regions across the globe. We don't want an account to be forever in the original datacenter it was created, so we have robust account move tooling which allows us to move an account to a new region with near-zero downtime.

The physical shifting of account data during a move generally has 2 phases, Bulk and Delta.

Bulk takes a snapshot of everything (eg `mysqldump`). Delta then consumes a change stream for the datastore to handle any updates that might have occurred to the account since bulk started.

While reading the change stream, our account move processes need to determine when they are up to date reading the change stream.

When there is data to process from the change stream, we get an exact calculation for how long ago the event read

The Skill of Using AI Agents Well

becausecurious · LessWrong

AI usage for this post: I wrote the draft on my own. While writing, I used Claude Code to look up references. Then Claude Code fixed typos and reviewed the draft, I addressed comments manually.

Epistemics: my own observations often inspired by conversations on X and Zvi's summaries.

As Zvi likes to repeat Language Models Offer Mundane Utility . Agent harnesses is the most advanced way to use language models. At the same time, they are not perfect - the capabilities frontier is jagged, sometimes they make mistakes and sometimes they just nuke your 15 year photo collection or production database . Thus, it is a skill how to use AI agents efficiently and I want to get better at it.

What tips, tricks, approaches are you using to improve your efficiency when using agent harnesses? I personally focus on Claude Code & Codex CLI mostly for single person software development, but I welcome suggestions for other tools and other areas of use. Ideally you share what you tried and what works for you and I try it myself and see whether it improves my workflow.

Here are my discoveries (with level of confidence).

Use best model and highest thinking/effort (no brainer)

The best available model and its thinking effort usually produces best results and requires less handholding. You have to be extra careful with what this means, e.g. Claude Code has high thinking effort by default, but the best level is max, which you need to actively turn on yourself. Unless you are very sensitive to speed and cost, you should do this. It might work a bit longer and consume more tokens, but this is much better than requiring multiple iterations from you.

worktrees (no brainer)

When working on code in a git repo, let each AI session have its own git branch with worktree. This way they can work in parallel and not fight to edit same files. Intuitively this would lead to merge hell, but fortunately AIs are good at merging.

/fast (depends on how you work)

Codex CLI allows you to turn on /fast mode, which speeds up processing 1.5 times, but consumes your token quota 2x faster. If you work on highly interactive tasks, which require lots of your input and you are not constrained by money (e.g. can afford \$200 subscription), you should do this. In my experience, without /fast, AI is slow enough that I can juggle 5-6 sessions before any finishes. With /fast, sessions finish quickly enough that I only need 2-3 at a time. The smaller batch means less context switching, which I find more productive overall.

The toggle is global, so it affects all your sessions at once.

Claude Code also has /fast to speed up processing 2.5 times, but don't run to turn it on yet - it charges you extra in addition to subscription using API prices and it is very expensive (\$2-5/minute/agent). I haven't tried it.

Verbose logging (depends on what you are working on)

I discovered that my software development efficiency grew greatly once I started having extremely verbose logging. The idea is once something goes wrong, this gives AI a trace of what has happened and I can just describe very briefly the higher-level symptom and it can investigate from the logs on its own. This is especially useful when the issue is hard to reproduce or happens occasionally. Another variation of this is to have some way to export debug information from your app and reference a specific object or instance. This way when something goes wrong, you just feed that to AI after one click and let it investigate.

AIs have bad days (sometimes)

I don't know the reason, but once in a while I get a couple days when AI just seems incapable of doing anything. Previously after one message it would correctly implement a bunch of stuff and now it keeps misunderstanding what I want and I need 30 iterations and it still does not get it and the process never converges. In this case I switch to the competitor (basically Opus 4.6 <> GPT5.4). The key is to detect this early and switch early. This is very sad, because migrating all the skills and setups between Claude Code and Codex sucks and I don't have an efficient way to do this.

Memory across sessions (WIP)

I haven't found a solution to this myself, but I strongly believe that this would have huge impact. I want the current AI session to seamlessly have access to all past information I provided to it. Both Claude and ChatGPT have this implemented in their web interfaces, but not in Claude Code / Codex CLI. I am currently experimenting with github.com/doobido/mcp-memory-service . Issues discovered:

It is developer oriented (e.g. mostly technical facts and choices), but I want generic memory system (e.g. for personal background too).

Autosaving of memories does not work - Claude ignores CLAUDE.md and the session end approach seems to be regexp based.

The memory retrieval seems to be fine. I am experimenting with using a separate Claude session in the background to extract memories from every message.

If you found a good solution you are happy with, please tell.

Ask to review in a new session (useful)

To my surprise just asking a new session of the same AI to review plan or work often brings useful insights, which the

Infiniti Taps NFL Star Power to Reveal 2027 QX65 in New York

Michael Strong · *The Truth About Cars*

After a few weeks of teases, Infiniti wanted to ensure the new 2027 QX65 would be a hit. Who knows more about hits than professional football players so former New England Patriots Rob Gronkowski and Julian Edelman took the stage March 26 to hype the coupe-style SUV.

Infiniti headed to the famous Grand Central Terminal in New York City looking to highlight its ongoing efforts to revive the luxury brand, hoping to generate some buzz with a staged “typical day in NY” scenario replete with Gronkowski and Edelman stepping off a train and walking through part of the terminal to “arrive” just in time for the reveal the Sunfire Red SUV.

While the staged event may make eyes roll, it reflects the level of importance Nissan’s luxury unit is placing on the new fastback ute’s arrival. Not only did it use the station’s famed Vanderbilt Hall to do the reveal, but it’ll also be on display there all weekend, before it moves to the Jacob K. Javits Center for the 2026 New York International Auto Show.

“The all-new 2027 Infiniti QX65 accelerates Infiniti into its next era, building on an impressive heritage of standout design language, luxurious client experiences and refined driver performance,” said Eric Ledieu, vice president, Infiniti Americas.

That design language mirrors the coupe or fastback look other luxury makers, such as BMW and Mercedes-Benz, have applied to their midsize SUV models, looking to tap into buyers who used to settle for a boxy midsize, but wanted something a little sportier. The new QX65 hits dealer showrooms this summer with a starting price of \$53,990.

“The all-new 2027 Infiniti QX65 invigorates the luxury space with a sporty fastback profile inspired by the spirit of the iconic FX, a cabin shaped by thoughtful hospitality, and responsive, rewarding performance. Designed for the heart of the midsize luxury segment, QX65 reflects Infiniti’s legacy of challenging convention,” the company noted.

Since it looks sporty, it should at least show a little in the performance department. The QX65 features a Variable Compression Turbo 2.0-liter inline-4 putting out 268 horsepower and 286 lb-ft of torque. It’s tied to a 9-speed automatic with paddle shifters so you can try to wring out a bit of extra power from it. All-wheel drive is standard and can tow up to 6,000 pounds.

With an aggressive look outside, and a reasonable drivetrain under the hood, the interior’s got to shine. Infiniti’s cabin is tech-forward with two 12.3-inch touchscreens, a Qi2 wireless charging pad standard — no more burning your hands on a hot phone — and depending upon which trim level you buy, you can get a 16-speaker, 600-watt or 20-speaker, 1,200-watt Klipsch sound system. Buyers can download Infiniti’s

Personalized Sound app to customize the sound quality of the QX65.

And while they’re checking it out, headroom isn’t too bad, the company contends. The stretched arch profile leads the eye toward the vehicle’s powerful rear stance, all while preserving utility with competitive cargo capacity: 35.8 cubic feet behind the second row and 67.7 cubic feet behind the first row.

[Images: Infiniti]

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The Original Attention Crisis

Study Hacks · Study Hacks (Cal Newport)

I recently heard from a historian of science at All Souls College, Oxford. He forwarded me an essay he wrote about Nicolaus Steno, a seventeenth-century anatomist and geologist who was later ordained as a Catholic Bishop.

Steno's training as a scholar unfolded in a period challenged by a novel problem: information overload. Here's how the essay describes it:

"Books were a leading distraction in the early modern period—and how envious we should be of those times. From the 1500s onward, with the development of the printing press and the humanist revival of ancient philosophies, knowledge became available at a much greater pace than ever before."

This created pressing questions for aspiring thinkers, including: "How do we decide what to read? How long should we read it for? Must every single chapter be excerpted?"

Part of the solution was the development of "new note-taking techniques," including the copying of excerpts into a master notebook called a book of commonplaces. (For more on this technique, I recommend William Powell's delightful 2010 techno-history, *Hamlet's Blackberry*).

But as the essay on Steno elaborates, better notes weren't enough on their own, as there were simply too many good books available. In response to this reality, Steno, during his university studies in the 1650s, innovated some more advanced attention management strategies:

"[H]e learned to focus on specific themes, rather than letting his mind read multiple things quickly. A 'harmful hastening should be avoided' as he put it. His solution was to 'stick to one topic.'"

In practice, that meant blocking specific moments of time to go through the hardest tasks. As he wrote in his personal notebook, 'before noon nothing must be done except medical things.' ... As Steno told a friend, he took 'almost all the morning hours' to read the works of the Church Fathers and old biblical manuscripts available at the Medici library."

In other words, Steno created a method that combines what we might now call slow productivity , deep work , and time blocking .

The lessons here are clear. The use of our brains to think deeply about meaningful ideas isn't new. It's been at the core of the human experience since the early modern period, when access to sophisticated information first became somewhat widespread.

The best practices developed back then remain the best practices today: avoid overload, focus on one thing at a time, and block off specific hours in your day for your most mentally demanding efforts.

AI Reality Check :

Two weeks ago, a small financial services firm, Citrini Research, published an essay describing a bleak scenario in which AI agents destroy the white-collar job market in the near future. The piece went viral and was cited as a factor in a modest decline of the S&P 500 the next day.

The Citrini essay wasn't the first to float this scenario. In recent weeks, there have been multiple credulous articles and op-eds in major publications proposing similar outcomes (e.g., 1 , 2 , and 3). But the negative impact on the stock market seems to have been the last straw for serious economists who began to push back on these technological ghost stories last week. (I particularly enjoyed a Deutsche Bank analyst who, perhaps borrowing some of my terminology, told the Times that the Citrini article had a "vibes-to-substance ratio" that was "undeniably high.")

If you're looking to reduce your blood pressure about this idea that AI is about to unravel the economy, I suggest reading a detailed response article published by an analyst from the Global Macro Strategies group at Citadel. It begins with a bit of finance geek sarcasm:

"Despite the macroeconomic community struggling to forecast 2-month-forward payroll growth with any reliable accuracy, the forward path of labor destruction can apparently be inferred with significant certainty from a hypothetical scenario posted on Substack..."

It then continues to systematically destabilize the economic naivety of these breathless op-eds and viral essays about how AI will dismantle the economy all at once. It certainly made me feel better.

(If you're looking for additional soothing of your AI anxiety, then you should also check the first episode of my new AI Reality Check podcast series, which I published last Thursday. I have a new episode of the series coming out this upcoming Thursday as well.)

The post The Original Attention Crisis appeared first on Cal Newport .

Photographing Spring Flowers with Artistic Intent

500px Blog · 500px ISO

Spring brings a burst of color and renewal, making it the perfect time to explore artistic interpretations of nature through photography. Photographing spring flowers with artistic intent goes beyond documentation, it's about evoking mood, emotion, and story. Here's how to bring a creative lens to your floral captures this season.

Before clicking the shutter, take a moment to consider what story or mood you want to convey through your image. Are you drawn to soft, romantic aesthetics? Or do you prefer bold colors and graphic shapes? Let this intention guide your composition and post-processing choices.

Use shallow depth of field (f/2.8–f/4) for dreamy, blurred backgrounds.

Frame your subject with natural elements to create depth and visual interest.

Light as Your Creative Partner

Photographing spring flowers with artistic intent means being intentional with lighting. Natural light, especially during golden hour, can add warmth and texture to your floral scenes.

Shoot during early morning or late afternoon for soft, diffused light.

Experiment with backlighting to highlight petal translucency.

Use a reflector or white surface to gently bounce light and reduce harsh shadows.

Explore Composition and Perspective

Change your vantage point to avoid typical top-down shots. Try photographing at flower level, from behind, or even through other foliage for a more immersive and unique perspective.

Incorporate negative space to evoke serenity or simplicity.

Try minimalist framing or off-center placement using the rule of thirds.

Play with Color and Texture

Spring offers a vibrant color palette. When photographing spring flowers with artistic intent, pay attention to complementary colors and repeating patterns. Let texture and color contrast carry the image's emotion.

Pro Tip: Create a Floral Series with Purpose

Instead of one-off shots, consider creating a cohesive photo series that explores a specific flower type, color palette, or compositional theme. This approach encourages consistency, deepens your understanding of visual storytelling, and can be shared as a collection that reflects your unique creative perspective.

Extended reading: Transforming ordinary scenes with vibrant colors

The post Photographing Spring Flowers with Artistic Intent appeared first on 500px .

Sounds Of Spring Start-up – 1969 BMW 2002

Michigan Automotive Relic Society | TTAC Creator · The Truth About Cars

After a long Michigan winter in storage, this BMW 2002 gets its first wake-up of the season.

This short cinematic ASMR piece captures the slow process of bringing it back to life — the quiet of the garage, the sound of cranking and priming, a little light tinkering, and finally that steady idle once everything settles in. No music. No talking. Just the mechanical rhythm of an old car remembering what it was built to do.

If you've got something tucked away for the winter, this is your sign. Check on it. Turn it over. The spring driving season is quickly approaching. SEE YOU OUT THERE!

Ed. note – this article originally appeared earlier this year, and we've moved it back to the front page, in case you missed it the first time.

The TTAC Creators Series tells stories and amplifies creators from all corners of the car world, including culture, dealerships, collections, modified builds and more.

[Image: YouTube/Michigan Automotive Relic Society]

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Zoox Expanding Operations for Second Time in March

Michael Strong · *The Truth About Cars*

If you're hoping to get a ride in one of the toaster-style robotaxis from Zoox, the odds are about to improve as the company's announced it will expand its operations in four cities: San Francisco, Las Vegas, Austin and Miami.

The announcement comes just a day after General Motors outlined its plans to begin testing its AI-based "eyes-off" variant of Super Cruise. Testing begins in Detroit and San Francisco using specially equipped Cadillac Escalade IQ SUVs. They're joined by several companies in various stages of autonomous technology development, including Waymo, Tesla, Nuro, Aurora Innovation, Motional, to name a few.

This marks the second time this month, the Amazon-owned company has revealed plans to expand. On March 9, it said it will establish its first fleet of vehicles in Phoenix and was adding a fleet in Dallas.

"This expansion marks a significant step forward for Zoox and is driven by the insights from our early deployments," said Aicha Evans, CEO, in a statement. "This is our year of growth. We are actively implementing learnings to confidently and safely scale our robotaxi service across the country and bring our differentiated experience to even more riders."

Zoox plans to expand service fourfold in San Francisco, providing coverage to a large section of the eastern half of the city. In

Las Vegas, it's doubling the number of locations to get service, including the Las Vegas Convention Center as well as most hotels on the Las Vegas Strip. In Vegas, the company is beginning shift from retrofitted vehicles to its toaster-on-wheels vehicles.

Like Las Vegas, Austin and Miami have been testing retrofitted vehicles and will begin the shift to Zoox's purpose-built model, which doesn't have any driver controls, but can carry up to six people at one time. Those vehicles will arrive in small numbers with Zoox employees and their families getting the first experiences. The size and coverage area will grow as the new models pass certain milestones, the company noted.

The Zoox robocabs cater to tech-savvy ride-share users. That starts with needing to use the app to secure a ride to the Zoox-Cast which allows riders to connect their Bluetooth-enabled devices to stream audio the vehicle.

Other improvements to the toaster, include "Find My Zoox," a feature where the robotaxi uses distinct lighting and sound cues to help riders identify their specific robotaxi in crowded pickup zones.

[Images: Zoox]

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24-Years-Owned 1997 Dodge Viper GTS

bringatrailer · Bring a Trailer

This 1997 Dodge Viper GTS was acquired by the selling dealer in December 2001, and 9k of the 25k kilometers (15k miles) shown have been added since that time. It has been registered in Ontario from new. The car is finished in Viper GTS Blue with white stripes over black leather and is powered by an 8.0-liter V10 paired with a six-speed manual transmission. Equipment includes a limited-slip differential, 17" five-spoke alloy wheels, a vented hood, projector-style headlights, a CD player, and power windows. This Viper GTS is now offered in Canada by the selling dealer with the owner's manual, memorabilia, a car cover, a clean Carfax report, and Ontario registration.

The car is finished in Viper GTS Blue (SBE) with white stripes and features projector-style headlights, fog lights, a vented hood, and dual center-exit exhaust outlets. Scuffs are present under the front bumper cover.

The 17" five-spoke alloy wheels are mounted with Michelin Pilot Sport tires, which show date codes from 2019. Braking is handled by four-wheel ventilated discs.

The cabin features bucket seats upholstered in black leather along with a color-matching dashboard, center console, door panels, and shift knob. Additional equipment includes a CD player, adjustable pedals, power windows, and dual airbags. The air conditioning system does not work.

The leather-wrapped steering wheel frames a 360-km/h speedometer and a tachometer with a 6k-rpm redline. Auxiliary gauges for coolant temperature, oil pressure, fuel level, and voltage are mounted atop the center stack. The six-digit odometer shows 25k kilometers (15k miles), approximately 9k of which were added under current ownership.

The 8.0-liter OHV V10 was factory rated at 450 horsepower and 490 lb-ft of torque. The radiator hoses were replaced in 2019, and the oil was most recently changed in the spring of 2025.

Power is sent to the rear wheels through a Tremec T-56 six-speed manual transmission and a limited-slip differential.

The Carfax report is free of accidents and other reported damage.

The vehicle is being sold on its Ontario registration, which serves as the ownership document in Ontario, Canada.

“This expansion marks a significant step forward for Zoox and is driven by the insights from our early deployments,” said Aicha Evans, CEO, in a statement.

Michael Strong

The 17" five-spoke alloy wheels are mounted with Michelin Pilot Sport tires, which show date codes from 2019.

bringatrailer

Honda Breaks Up with Sony, Ending Afeela EV Before It Arrives

Michael Strong · *The Truth About Cars*

Honda's push to shore up its finances claimed another electric vehicle casualty, the Afeela, which was to be built through a joint venture with electronics giant Sony.

Sony Honda Mobility Inc. came to life in September 2022 with the goal of producing a new, innovative EV, marrying Honda's automotive know-how with Sony's sensor and electronics expertise. Several prototypes were produced, but the venture never delivered a vehicle to a customer. It was slated to be built at Honda's plant in East Liberty, Ohio.

"Sony, Honda and SHM will continue to discuss and evaluate the future of SHM, taking into account the initial purpose of the JV establishment as well as the latest EV market environment, and intend to jointly announce SHM's future direction, mid to long-term positioning as well as contributions to the future of mobility at the earliest possible opportunity," according to the release issued by the companies.

Honda noted it's "reassessment of its automobile electrification strategy" earlier this month was the catalyst for the end of the partnership. The first Afeela 1 sedans were supposed to arrive later this year. The crossover model, which was set to come after that, was based on Honda's 0 Series electric vehicles.

The 0 Series sedan and SUV, along with the Acura RSX, were cancelled as part

of the effort to deal with potential \$15.8 billion loss for Honda's 2026 fiscal year. Honda officials noted that increased U. S. tariffs as well as waning demand — at the time — for EVs made the move a necessity.

The company is also expected stop producing the Prologue, which it produced in concert with General Motors, at the end of the year. A second-generation version — designed solely by Honda — was expected for 2027, but the company has no plan for that now.

The Japanese automaker joins a long list of automakers scaling back their EV plans, including Ford, GM, Stellantis, Hyundai and Volkswagen. While the U. S. market has suddenly become more difficult, Honda's fallen behind competitors in the Asian market due to its investment in EV development, officials noted.

Honda officials said earlier this month the company will refocus on hybrids as part of its push to return to profitability.

[Images: Sony Honda Mobility]

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Recall Alert: 2026 Hyundai Palisade

TTAC Staff · *The Truth About Cars*

Today's recall alert involves the 2026 Hyundai Palisade.

Hyundai is recalling 46,787 units of the 2026 Palisade and Palisade Hybrid in Limited and Calligraphy trims over a fault tied to the third-row seat belt.

According to the filing, wiring inside the driver-side third-row seat belt buckle can become damaged. When that happens, the system may incorrectly show the seat as buckled at all times on the instrument cluster, regardless of whether it actually is.

The issue doesn't involve the belt physically failing, but it does create a false status reading that could lead to occupants not being properly restrained without the driver realizing it.

To fix it, dealers will install a wiring harness extension and replace the seat belt assembly if needed, at no cost. Hyundai plans to begin notifying owners by mail starting May 18, 2026.

Disclosure: This article was partially written by AI and edited by a human staffer.

[Image: Hyundai]

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To fix it, dealers will install a wiring harness extension and replace the seat belt assembly if needed, at no cost.

TTAC Staff

Capturing Early Signs of Spring in Nature Photography

500px Blog · 500px ISO

As winter fades and subtle signs of spring begin to appear, nature photography becomes a celebration of quiet transformation. From budding trees to thawing streams, capturing the early signs of spring allows photographers to document this seasonal shift with creativity and intent.

Look for Subtle Seasonal Changes

Photographing early spring means training your eye to notice the small things. Melting snow revealing patches of earth, the first green shoots pushing through the soil, or early blooms like crocuses and snowdrops can all signal the change in season.

These quiet moments may seem minor, but they're powerful storytelling elements when captured thoughtfully.

Timing and Light for Early Spring Scenes

The best time to photograph early spring is often during early morning or late afternoon when the light is soft and directional. These golden hour conditions bring out textures, enhance colors, and create gentle contrast.

Overcast days can also be perfect for capturing delicate scenes, diffused light enhances details without harsh shadows, especially useful when shooting close-ups of early flowers or fresh dew.

Pro Tip: Embrace the Mood of Transition

Early spring scenes carry a unique quietness. Use minimalist compositions, soft depth of field, and muted tones to reflect that calm mood. This approach can elevate your images from simple documentation to emotional storytelling.

Composition Ideas for Spring Transitions

Shoot wide shots that contrast remaining snow with patches of growth.

Capture close-ups of blooming buds or raindrops on new leaves.

Use reflections in puddles or streams to add visual interest and depth.

Gear to Bring for early signs of spring in nature photography

Pack a macro lens or use a wide-aperture prime lens to get crisp, detailed shots of small subjects. A tripod can help with steady close-ups or low-light situations, especially in shaded forest areas or misty mornings.

Extended reading: Mastering winter landscapes in photography

The post Capturing Early Signs of Spring in Nature Photography appeared first on 500px .

2009 Toyota Vellfire at No Reserve

bringatrailer · Bring a Trailer

This 2009 Toyota Vellfire is a Japanese-market van that was acquired by the selling dealer and imported to Canada in 2026. Finished in White Crystal Shine over black cloth, it is powered by a 2.4-liter inline-four mated to a CVT automatic transmission. Features include antilock disc brakes, 20" Loxarny Tarkus alloy wheels, an Admiration lower aero package, xenon headlights, dual sunroofs, dual sliding side doors, a rear spoiler, front bucket seats, second- and third-row benches, dual-zone automatic climate control, privacy curtains, a rearview camera, and a Bluetooth-capable Kenwood touchscreen infotainment system. This Vellfire has 108k kilometers (68k miles) and is offered at no reserve by the selling dealer with a British Columbia registration.

The van is finished in White Crystal Shine and features a color-matched Admiration lower aero package. Exterior details include yellow fog lights, xenon headlights, power-folding side mirrors, tinted vent shades, dual sunroofs, a rear spoiler, clear taillights, front and rear parking sensors, and dual sliding side doors, the left of which is power-operated.

Black-finished 20" Loxarny Tarkus alloy wheels are mounted with Kenda Kuavela SL tires. Antilock braking is handled by four-wheel discs.

The front bucket seats and split-folding second- and third-row benches are trimmed in black cloth.

Woodgrain trim accents the dashboard and door panels, and additional appointments include push-button ignition, dual-zone automatic climate control, ambient lighting, privacy curtains, a rearview camera, and a Kenwood touchscreen infotainment system with Bluetooth connectivity.

The leather- and woodgrain-trimmed steering wheel frames a central digital display, a 180-km/h speedometer, an 8k-rpm speedometer, and gauges for coolant temperature and fuel level. The digital odometer indicates 109k kilometers (68k Miles).

The 2.4-liter 2AZ-FE inline-four was factory rated at 168 horsepower and 165 lb-ft of torque.

Power is sent to the front wheels through a CVT automatic transmission.

The car is being sold on its British Columbia registration, which serves as the ownership document in British Columbia, Canada. The vehicle is not yet 25 years old, and it has not been federalized for the US market.

Parkinson's Law of Worry

Jakub Halmeš · LessWrong

Parkinson's law says that "Work expands so as to fill the time available for its completion." I think that a similar observation can be made for people worrying about stuff. To paraphrase: "Problem salience expands so as to fill the capacity available for worrying."

Suppose a person is worried about several problems. Let's visualize the mental state of this person, where each problem is represented by a colored circle, and the size of the circle corresponds to how much this problem occupies the person:

This person worries about 5 things, with the yellow and green ones being the most important ones.

This person worries about 5 things, with the yellow and green ones being the most important ones.

Now, when one of these problems is resolved, one would expect that this problem simply gets removed from the 'mental space', making the person less worried in proportion to the size of the resolved problem:

The person now worries less, because the big problem was resolved.

Naive expectation: The person now worries less, because the big problem was resolved.

However, I don't think this accurately describes what actually happens! Instead, it seems that the unresolved problems become more salient to the person, as if to fill the available space in the person's mental state:

Or, new problems pop inside the freed space — the problems which weren't important enough to worry about as long as there were more pressing ones:

The upshot is that in the beginning, the person would be wrong to think that they will worry much less or be much happier after the most important problems are resolved. They will just worry about different things!

What could help to prevent this scenario is to try to periodically recall some of the resolved problems and the amount of worrying they caused before they were resolved. By remembering this, the importance of other problems can shrink again (it's relative, so they should still be less important than the yellow problem was!).

Related concepts: Adaptation level theory, hedonic treadmill, gratitude, negative visualization.

ANALYSIS

Calin Van Paris, Yoga Journal: A little movement can make a major difference.

The post [Got 5 Minutes? These YouTube Yoga Practices Will Fit in Your Morning Routine.](#) appeared first on [Yoga Journal](#).

Ahmad Ibsais, The Nation: Ahmad Ibsais

It's not just Gaza—Israel wants to exterminate all Palestinians, everywhere. We are one people being destroyed as one people.

The post [Israel Is Also Committing Genocide In the West Bank](#) appeared first on [The Nation](#) .

Hoyt Patrick Taylor IV, Nature News: Nature, Published online: 25 March 2026; doi:10.1038/s41586-026-10219-x

fMRI data from individuals of a wide range of ages (from a few days to 100 years old) are used to map the key organizational axes of functional connectivity in the human cortex throughout the lifespan.

Calin Van Paris, Yoga Journal: Right place, best practice.

The post [I Hated Yoga Until I Found the Right Studio. Here's How to Find the Perfect Place to Practice.](#) appeared first on [Yoga Journal](#).

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A mayoral candidate in Providence argues that unique challenges and unique responses must be explored.

The post The Affordability Crisis in Midsize Cities Is Not Inevitable appeared first on The Nation .

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